

The Hague's SOS to Brussels

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-08-18 13:48

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By MAX GRIERA GOEDEMORGEN

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GOEDEMORGEN FROMDEN HAAG! I'm Max Griera, joining you from the Netherlands for Day 2 of Playbook on the road. Tomorrow: sun-scorched Madrid.

In today's Playbook:

- Can the EU help the Netherlands with a seven-year political tussle over nitrogen?
- Tallying the proceeds of crime on the mean streets of Brussels.
- Faces in the crowd: Jaimi van Essen, Isabelle Krauss, Honorine Schwarz, Thomas Byrne, Wouter Beke, Rob Jetten, Andrii Sybiha, Piet Mondrian, Itamar Ben-Gvir, Hamish Falconer and more.

DRIVING THE DAY

BREATHING ROOM, PLEASE: The Netherlands' centrist government is asking the European Commission for more flexibility in applying EU nature rules, in a bid to break a seven-year crisis that has stalled housing, farms and industrial projects and become a flashpoint for the far right.

"I really need [the Commission's] support now," Agriculture Minister Jaimi van Essen told Playbook from his office in The Hague, overlooking a patio shared with the economy ministry.

How did we get here? The Netherlands has one of Europe's most intensive livestock sectors. Years of nitrogen pollution — much of it from farming — have left protected nature reserves in poor condition. EU law requires governments to prevent those habitats deteriorating further, making it difficult for Dutch authorities to approve building projects that would add more nitrogen near damaged nature.

It got even tougher after a Dutch court ruled in 2019 that promises to offset pollution weren't enough to justify permits.

The building paralysis costs the Dutch economy around €15 billion a year, van Essen said, adding that his priority is to unlock housing and projects around Eindhoven — the high-tech hub that's home to chipmaking giant ASML — and the Port of Rotterdam, one of Europe's biggest trade hubs.

State of play: Van Essen belongs to Prime Minister Rob Jetten's centrist Democrats 66, which formed a minority government with the center-right VVD and the Christian Democrats after winning the election in October. Jetten is facing the tough task of striking a budget agreement by the end of August to avoid another political crisis potentially toppling the coalition.

The centrist government needs to show it can solve the crisis "in order to stop the growth of the far right," said van Essen, who has made €20 billion available to help farmers reduce nitrogen. The government has secured the support of the center-left PRO party for a nitrogen-reduction package — to be submitted to the parliament in October.

Rallying point: Nitrogen has become a defining political issue in the Netherlands, dominating successive elections, driving support for farmer protest parties and feeding broader anti-EU sentiment.

The Netherlands wants the Commission to say that authorities can approve projects that pollute now but deliver environmental gains over time. Van Essen's hope is that official Commission guidance will give courts grounds to interpret the EU's nature laws less restrictively, with permits flowing again and farmers' anger waning. The minister says he isn't asking Brussels to weaken environmental protection rules, just to apply them more flexibly.

On the chopping block: The laws are already in the crosshairs of a broader deregulation push led by the center-right European People's Party, the dominant EU political force. "We need a better balance between environmental protection and the investments needed for the transition," Belgian EPP head of delegation Wouter Beke told Playbook.

Red tape slashing: Meanwhile, the Commission is asking capitals and NGOs how to make the rules easier to apply and strip out bureaucracy. It'll decide by the end of year whether to reopen the directives, as part of the ongoing deregulation drive in Brussels.

BIG AND BREAKING

CALL FOR ROSATOM SANCTIONS: Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha called on the EU to sanction the Russian state nuclear company Rosatom after a POLITICO investigation pointed to alleged safety and engineering failures at a flagship project.

EUROSTAR'S MONOPOLY AT RISK: Virgin Trains has been granted track access that could allow it to run up to 20 daily return services through the Channel Tunnel from 2030, Daria Zakharova reports.

BRAIN REGAIN? NOT SO FAST: Greece's attempt to lure top scientists back to their homeland following the financial crisis has stalled, with an ambitious program to reverse the brain drain descending into fiasco, Nektaria Stamouli reports.

PULLING THE PLUG: What would happen if Europe suddenly lost access to U.S. tech? To find out, POLITICO's Mathieu Pollet went 72 hours without an iPhone, Google, WhatsApp and U.S. payment platforms — and lived to tell the tale.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

IT'S A DATE — ALMOST: Brussels and London are "determined" to hold the second U.K.-EU summit this fall, Irish EU Minister Thomas Byrne told Playbook after meeting with his British counterpart Hamish

Falconer. More for subscribers in Morning Trade UK .

ANTI-VIRUS FOR ICE CREAM: Ice cream makers, Christmas lights manufacturers and German landlords are on track to be classified as critical infrastructure eligible for additional EU protection from cyberattacks , Sam Clark reports.

LIB DEMS PLAY BALL WITH BURNHAM: The U.K.'s centrist Liberal Democrats have studiously avoided criticizing the new Labour prime minister — for now, Noah Keate reports.

THE HAGUE CORNER

CONTINUING PLAYBOOK'S CULTURAL TOUR DES CAPITALES ... Housed in a luminous modernist building, The Hague's Kunstmuseum boasts the world's largest collection of Piet Mondrian — famed for his grids of primary-colored squares. There's also an entire section devoted to De Stijl, the Dutch movement Mondrian helped create, defined by simplicity, abstraction and function. Check it out, along with the museum's other temporary exhibitions .

And for a koffiepauze: Head over to Bookstor, a 102-year-old cozy café-cum-bookshop in the city center with a large selection of poetry, essays ... and chess boards. Get lost in a corner, sunbathe on the back terrace or be mesmerized by the drawings covering the wooden walls.

If you're a political wonk: Playbook recommends skipping the Parliament tour for now, as the beautiful old Binnenhof complex has been a construction site since 2021 and isn't due to reopen until 2031. The assembly currently sits in a hulking brutalist block more reminiscent of a prison more than a European house of democracy.

Instead, check out the Peace Palace, home to the U.N. International Court of Justice, which has a free exhibition on its history and mission.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy with a chance of rain, high of 23C.

AUGUST FESTIVITIES CONTINUE: Brussels City Hall opens its doors from Wednesday through Sunday for an "immersive" dance performance in the historic corridors of the UNESCO-listed building to celebrate Brussels' heritage. Tickets and schedules here.

PROCEEDS OF CRIME: Brussels City-Ixelles Police yesterday published its annual enforcement tally for the city center: 549 reports for offenses ranging from illegal employment and illicit trade to counterfeiting and public nuisance, with crimes targeting businesses including restaurants, cafés, vape shops, nail salons, souvenir stores and sex shops.

The loot: The unit seized more than €420,000 in cash and goods, including 8,387 units of poppers, 6,000 e-cigarettes, 366 packs of cigarettes, 67 kilograms of shisha tobacco, 353 counterfeit items, 47 prohibited weapons and 1,500 fireworks. BX1 has the report.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Germany's support for Israel is facing a fresh test after a senior conservative lawmaker called for EU sanctions against Itamar Ben-Gvir.

Paris: Gérald Darmanin's sudden but not unexpected exit from the presidential race has added momentum to Edouard Philippe's campaign.

London: No. 10 is stonewalling on POLITICO's scoop that Andy Burnham swapped messages with a fake Susie Wiles, offering no explanation on how the PM was duped.

Washington: Some Democrats think they need their own Stephen Miller to manage the party's immigration policy ahead of the 2028 presidential election.

Canberra: A breakthrough on contentious gambling laws is now on the cards , following the government's introduction of an opt-out register for online advertising.

BIRTHDAYS

Former Vice President of the European Commission Věra Jourová; The Parliament's Federica Di Sario; SZ Dossier's Laurenz Gehrke; Ava Lloyd from AstraZeneca; ECOS' Mathilde Crêpy; Tim Nuthall from the Global Strategic Communications Council; European Commission's Isabelle Krauss; Occitanie Europe's Honorine Schwarz; Polish politician Zbigniew Ziobro, a POLITICO 28 alum; and POLITICO's Hanne Cokelaere and Laura Prier.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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